Project Access: Digitizing a Museum Collection

Johanna Forsberg
Army Museum
Box 14095
104 41 Stockholm
Sweden
+46 8 51 95 63 43 (Tel)
+46 8 662 68 31 (Fax)
johanna.forsberg@armemuseum.se

Abstract

For a few years the Army Museum has worked with publishing our collections on the Internet. The work is a multi layer process and is the result of a systematic inventorying project that began in 2006. The regular museum staff has worked alongside temporarily hired staff to bring the project to an end. Our goal is to have a complete inventory of the museum's collection by the end of 2008 and to be the first museum to publish an entire museum collection online. To reach this goal we had to look at the big picture. We couldn't allow ourselves to get bogged down in the details. We have chosen a few fields from the database that we believe is of general interest to publish on the Internet. More effort has been put on making those fields public than others. Therefore our presentation online is meant more as an overview than a detailed academic record. This method will allow us to reach a wider audience since we believe many online viewers will find our level of knowledge to be of a satisfying level. It is our intent to spur interest in the novice and further inquiry from the expert. We also believe that by using this technique we will reach our goal of a complete digital record of our museums entire inventory by the end of 2009.

The work of making our collection available on the Internet has been going on for a few years. The keyword for our work is accessibility. Our ambitions with the project are high; our

Museum Director has set the goal that the Army Museum is going to be the first museum in the world to publish an entire museum collection on the Internet! The intention is to have this finished by the end of 2009. Rather than a detailed academic record, the presentation of the online collection is meant as an overview. This work is only possible thanks to an extensive inventorying project that was successfully implemented by the Army Museum two and a half years ago. Fifteen additional people within the field of cultural studies were hired in March 2006. Working side by side with permanent museum staff these additional persons are critical to achieving our goal. The funds for this project were provided by the Swedish government for the specific purpose of caring for the museum collections and making collections accessible to the public through modern Internet and database technology.

The overall goal with the inventory project is getting an overview of the museum collection and that by the 31st of December 2008 our entire collection of about 100 000 objects shall be inventoried and photographed, ready to publish on the Internet. Several project groups work in our storage inventorying and photographing all different kinds of objects. The artifacts in our collection range from flags and uniforms to weapons and everyday items. Many of our flags belong to the internationally unique trophy collection. The work groups were initially divided after skills in handling computers, photographing and so on, but by now everyone handle all different elements of the work. At the Army Museum it has been very important that the 15 extra people that were hired to work with the project became an integrated part of the museum. This has also proven to be one of the strengths of the inventory work. Working side by side, the experience and the quality of the work from the regular staff are passed on to the new colleagues. Regular museum staffs as well as new colleagues work as project leaders. Methods have been set up how to work with the different steps in the inventory process; how to handle and pack objects, how to photograph, how to work with the database and so on. If

the museum were to do this with only the regular museum staff the project would take about 89 years to finish! As it looks today, the project will finish on time.

Alongside with the storage inventorying groups a smaller group of people work with preparing our database for the Internet. This is also a part of the overall Access-project and the goal for 2008 is to have 25 000 objects published online and the entire museum collection by the end of 2009. The general goal with this work is to raise awareness and availability of the collection. The entire museum catalogue has been computerized for a few years, but we still have a lot of extra information to add from different sources. The information on each individual object in our museum catalogue was of course not written in the exact order and routine over the years that our museum has existed, and this means that the information is not always consequent. Therefore many of our items in the database also need thorough editing. Those who work with the database started working with the inventorying project in our storage and hence they know all parts of that project in detail. The work in the storage is the fundament for the Internet preparing work; especially since the inventory project provide the database with photos of the items. We want all of our items to have photographs on the Internet since we believe it enriches the item itself.

Our database, Primus, a Norwegian system, has a web application tool, which makes it technically easy for us to publish our collections on the Internet. By clicking a specific publish button an item will be displayed on the Internet the next day. The reasons why we want to show our collection on the Internet are numerous. The politicians put pressure on us to open up and make our objects that are not displayed at the museum available to a wider audience, the museum itself wants to attract a broader audience and of course we want to make our fantastic objects known throughout the world.

So far this might seem easy and uncomplicated. But the step to click this one single button in our database has been preceded by long discussions on how to work to accomplish our goal. Our digitalizing project has very high ambitions. At the same time our experience from other similar projects is that several digitalizing projects never finish because of their high ambitions. Many projects simply want to accomplish too much at the same time. You want to show all information you have of a single item and that way you often get stuck on the way and never reach your goal. To reach our goal with the database online, the museum has set a guideline for our editing work. To avoid getting stuck in details we have developed techniques that allow us to streamline the cataloguing process. For example we do not edit all fields in the database, such as moving information to fields where it actually belongs. We also do know that our staff has a lot of knowledge to add and that we also have un-digitalized information to insert. But at this moment we believe there is a bigger win to have our entire collection with a little amount of information published, rather than a few objects with a lot of information available. The quantity in this case equals high quality. To clean up the database entirely and to add more information is a completely different project.

For some of our colleagues these streamlined guidelines have been hard to accept. As an ambitious person you always want to make your best and use all of your knowledge. This has also been a challenge in our inventory project. Especially our photographers are keen on taking detailed photos of interesting objects. But only spending one more minute on every single item would prolong the entire project with a few months, hence there is no such time for deepened studies. For our project leaders it has not always been easy to constantly remind the colleagues of this and keep them focused on the overall goal. Also those who work with the database feel that they want to add more information to an object when they are editing the information for the Internet. Especially those who are experts on specific types of items want to add more information and use more of their knowledge.

Some may criticize us for being less thorough but let's not forget the objective. The purpose of this project is to publish the entire museum collection, not to result in deepened studies. We are building a framework of basic information. The details will be added later. Researchers and academics are welcome to contact the Army Museum for further study. This of course also raises the question of who is the Internet for? It is difficult to find a way to please both the experts as well as those who do not know so much about our field. We believe that our way of promoting quantity rather than a rich amount of information is a way to make both groups pleased. The experts will see how rich our collections are and the other group will find the level satisfying. We also believe that the experts who want to know more will contact us or visit us in their search for deepened information. Having our collections on the Internet will in some ways make our work easier; the scholars, students and laypersons will be able to ask direct questions on individual objects that they are interested in.

In our digitalizing project we have been forced to deal with many other questions besides those earlier mentioned. For example we have been hit by a classical museum discussion; what are the items to be called? What is the "name" of an object? This question has led to long debates between our co-workers and has for some time slowed down the work. We have now reached a level that we all accept but we have also agreed on that it varies depending on what group of objects an item belongs to. Another challenge has been getting along with the three other Swedish museums that are also using the Primus database. The system has no individual adaptations; it looks the same for all museums. This is supposed to make it easier to combine searches from several different Internet based databases in the future. Of course it would be even better if all museums in Sweden used the same database. That way we could adapt the information from all the Swedish museums to the audience online. Instead of making searches from several different online collections the search for knowledge would be satisfied easier. The Army Museum feels that we have no information to hide; we want our

database to be open and available to everyone. There is no secret who has used our objects in the past or who has given them to the museum, that's why we put a lot of effort on making fields containing that kind of information available online. That type of information is what we believe is of interest for our viewers and a lot of the questions to the museum concern genealogy. You also have to remember that a lot of our objects are anonymous, but they still are of interest to a lot of people since military objects is a great field for private collectors. Some of the other museums don't feel the same way about showing this kind of information on the Internet and that's why we have been forced to compromise a lot. I believe that a lot of the compromising has resulted in a more efficient and well adapted database, not only for us but also for the other museums.

The Access-project has been a big success for the Army Museum, the inventory part of the project as well as the digitalizing part. One might think that the natural next step to continue working with the collections online is to add all the extra information we have of our objects. But another way to increase the access to our collections and make them available to the entire world is to develop the database by translating it to English. Or maybe the next step is to develop a Wikipedia function? As you can see the possibilities are numerous, though we haven't decided yet and at the moment our focus is on getting our entire collection available online at the end of 2009.

A project like this has never been run by the Army museum before. The founder of the project is the Head of collections who has also been a key actor throughout the entire project. Her enthusiasm, strong will and believe that the project will finish on time has been a great motivation for everyone involved. The implementation of the project has been possible thanks to her long museum carrier and experience from the cultural work field. The goal with the project was set from the very beginning and was also clear from the start. I believe this has

been an important fact throughout the entire project. The project started more or less with an empty sheet. Of course some experience was drawn from earlier projects of the same kind, but to the greatest extent the project was developed by the Army museum and adapted to the reality of the museum and its resources.